

Trump proudly touts sweeping tariffs



“THE STORM windows have stayed open and given us a good boost,” a state official said. This year’s snow-pack, at 96% of average, followed a very wet, snowy 2023 and a wet 2024. Above, Mammoth Rock in February.

A Sierra Nevada bounty 3 years straight

Latest survey’s near-average snowpack caps a string not seen in a quarter-century.

BY IAN JAMES

The year may have started with a dry spell, but the end of California’s storm season has brought more fresh snow to the Sierra Nevada, pushing the state’s snowpack to 96% of average on April 1, when the snow season typically reaches its peak.

The near-average snowpack has given the state a third straight year of ample water supplies in the mountains — something that hasn’t happened in a quarter of a century.

“Earlier on, there were some indicators that we might have a dry year, but fortunately, the storm windows have stayed open and given us a good boost in February and March to be where we are today,” said Andy Reising, manager of snow surveys and water supply forecasting for the California Department of Water Resources.

This near-average winter followed an extremely wet and snowy 2023 and a wet 2024. This time last year, the snowpack measured 111% of average.

The dominance of wet weather has brought a reprieve from the severe drought Californians endured from 2020 through 2022, the state’s driest three-year period on record.

The last time California had three consecutive years of average or above-average snow was from 1998 to 2000, Reising said. At that point, it had been 20 years since a similar pattern occurred, from 1978 to 1980.

This year’s storms have brought ample rains at lower elevations, and statewide precipitation since Oct. 1 measures 103% of average for this time of year.

The last two wet years have also left California’s [See **Snowpack**, A6]

A window into life on San Quentin death row

Inmate puts his collection of journals, recipes, personal items up for sale at prestigious book fair

By Hannah Wiley

SAN FRANCISCO — In early 2020, Albert Jones was sitting in his cell on San Quentin’s death row, as he had every day for nearly three decades, when reports of a mysterious respiratory illness started to circulate.

In the following months, hundreds of death row inmates fell sick as COVID-19 swept through San Quentin State Prison’s east block, the crowded warren of concrete and iron cells, stacked five stories high, that for decades housed many of California’s most notorious criminals.

By the end of August 2020, more than 2,200 prisoners and 270 staff members at San Quentin had fallen ill. One officer and 28 inmates died from their illness, including at least a dozen condemned men.

Through it all, Jones kept detailed journals chronicling his anxiety over catching the “killer virus.” And when he did contract COVID, he recounted his agonizing recovery.

“The world is on lock-down. This state is on full lock down,” Jones wrote at the start of the pan- [See **Inmate**, A12]



AURELIEN MORISSARD Pool Photo

OPENAI released ChatGPT in 2022, setting off a race among tech companies that could change how people work. Above, CEO Sam Altman in Paris in February.

A \$40-billion AI ‘gold rush’

Latest investment round gives maker of ChatGPT a valuation of \$300 billion.

BY QUEENIE WONG AND WENDY LEE

SAN FRANCISCO — ChatGPT maker OpenAI this week announced it had raised a whopping \$40 billion as it races to dominate a competitive AI landscape against tech giants such as Google and other rivals in-

cluding Anthropic and Chinese upstart DeepSeek.

The investment was the highest ever raised for a startup and places OpenAI at a \$300-billion valuation, tied with TikTok parent company ByteDance and behind the \$350-billion valuation for Elon Musk’s SpaceX, according to research firm CB Insights.

“It’s a gold rush of epic proportions of gold rushes before,” said Ben Bajarin, chief executive and principal analyst at San José-based consulting firm Creative Strategies. “They’re not sit-

ting on hoards of cash like Amazon, Microsoft and Google. ... They have to raise that money in order to compete with those three companies and that’s what you’re seeing.”

OpenAI’s funding round shows how much investors are willing to pour into technology that has the potential to disrupt entertainment, healthcare, education and other major industries. The rising popularity of ChatGPT, released in 2022, set off a race among tech companies that could [See **OpenAI**, A9]

The rates increase U.S. import taxes to a level not seen since WWII, raise specter of trade war

BY FAITH E. PINHO, MICHAEL WILNER AND KATE LINTHICUM

WASHINGTON — President Trump announced sweeping global tariffs Wednesday — a risky move that he vowed would lure manufacturing back to the United States, but which experts warned could upend the global economy.

In a Rose Garden speech, Trump said the U.S. would begin applying a universal baseline tariff of 10% on imported goods from all foreign countries. Several dozen countries that he said unfairly tax American-made goods will face additional tariffs, he said, with China being slapped with another 34% tariff, the European Union a 20% tariff, and India a 26% tariff.

The rates Trump announced increase U.S. import taxes on foreign goods to levels not seen since World War II, and raised the specter of a global trade war.

Trump said the new tariffs represent a turning point

Some face even higher duties

The United States would apply a baseline 10% tariff on imported goods from other countries, with additional “reciprocal” tariffs on some countries including:

- China: 34%
- European Union: 20%
- South Korea: 25%
- India: 26%
- Vietnam: 46%
- Taiwan: 32%
- Japan: 24%
- Thailand: 36%
- Switzerland: 31%
- Indonesia: 32%
- Malaysia: 24%
- Cambodia: 49%

globally and for the United States. He said that Wednesday, which he dubbed “Liberation Day,” would “forever be remembered as the day that American industry was reborn, the day America’s destiny was reclaimed, and the day that [See **Tariffs**, A6]



MARK SCHIEFELBEIN Associated Press

PRESIDENT Trump said Wednesday would “forever be remembered” as what he called “Liberation Day.”

Even mild cases of measles can cause serious problems

The virus could lead to ‘immune amnesia,’ opening the door for other illnesses.

BY CORINNE PURTILL

Dr. Adam Ratner has heard a lot of myths and misunderstandings about measles in his decades as a New York City pediatric infectious disease specialist.

A troubling untruth he’s seen circulating on social media during the current outbreak is that being infected with the virus instead of getting vaccinated confers benefits on the immune system — a strength-training program of sorts for the cells.

The truth, Ratner said, “is exactly the opposite.”

Measles is a highly contagious virus that presents as a rash and cold-like symptoms for many patients and can lead to serious or fatal complications for others. An outbreak that began in west Texas in January has since infected nearly 500 people across 19 states, including eight people in California.

An insidious but lesser-known consequence of even a mild measles infection is that it kills the very cells that remember which pathogens the patient has previously fought and how those battles were won. As a result, recurring bugs that might have caused only minor symptoms make patients as sick as if they’d never en- [See **Measles**, A12]

Val Kilmer, ‘Top Gun’ star, dies at 65

The actor, who had survived throat cancer, died of pneumonia, his daughter says. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

County OKs new homeless agency

Board of Supervisors’ plan comes despite warnings from L.A.’s mayor. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

An afternoon shower. L.A. Basin: 66/46. **B6**

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Becerra joins governor’s race

The former U.S. Health secretary is jumping into a crowded field. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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